

Em



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WELCOME DRINK

Japanese inspired seaweed and fish dashi
infused with Mexican cactus and hoja santa

SNACK

Bocol tortilla filled with requesón cheese
topped with rib eye tartare and cactus salad

TUNA

Bluefin tuna crudo
Pasilla mixe chili kōshō and Soy reduction
Avocado puree with fried fish scale

BRIOCHE

Butter with totemoxtle ash

SHORT RIB

Braised short-rib covered with mole negro
beans puree, pineapple and guajillo puree, borage flower

PALATE CLEANSER

Shiso leaf roll with mint marshmallow, yuzu, and cucumber

MAMEY TIRAMISU

Fresh mamey, pistache cream and mascarpone, mamey powder

MIGNARDIS

Nama chocolate with caramel and gold foil



Restaurant Em proved its status in the gastronomy world of Mexican city when it gets a star in the very first Michelin guide of Mexico. Restaurant Em is known for its Japanese-Mexican fusion style of cooking, making me wonder how these two drastically different culture can be mix with the hand of Lucho Martínez. Japanese fusion is a far cry from innovative, nearly all the fine dining restaurants in the Europe and America is favoring this now ubiquitous French-Japanese fusion. Some of them, including Alain Passard, the Troigrois, and Anne-Sophie Pic, keep their French heritage while learn from the Japanese and make their dishes lighter and more refreshingly elegant; Others, like Cesar Ramirez of the Chef's Table at Brooklyn Fare, choose to lean more towards Japanese ingredients, and let them shine in a unique way through the mixture of French and Japanese cooking techniques. While French-Japanese has taken the world by storm, we have yet never seen any restaurant mixing Japanese and Mexican cooking. As I believe, Mexican cuisine is yet largely unknown to the majority of the world beyond taco, and thus many cutting edge restaurants, like Quintonil and Pujol, is pushing forward the development of its own cuisine. Em is the first to take the bold step to try mixing its heritage with something from the far east. That being said, will this work? The answer might be found after a short a la carte dinner at the restaurant.



For my short trip to Mexico, Em is the very last restaurant among the six that I decided to pay a visit. I made the reservation just a few days ahead. Upon arriving at the restaurant, I realized I had been misled by their Instagram photos. Em's online images feature a black background with emerald-obsidian colored marble tables, exuding a kind of minimalist hypoactive charm and coolness. However, the actual restaurant takes a completely different approach, with artistic and cozy decor, filled with pink tones. I was seated at a small table in the corner; while the space was tight, it wasn't cramped, and it was quite comfortable to sit in. Soon, the waiter presented the menu for the evening. I opted for the à la carte ordering, to my surprise, the selection was much more limited than I had expected. They don't publish their menu online, and comparing it to photos of the menu from a while back, the current choices were disappointingly few. Nonetheless, this didn't prevent me from sampling their classic dishes.



Like many fine dining restaurants, Em offered complimentary amuse bouches before presenting the ordered dishes. The first was a Japanese-inspired seaweed and fish dashi infused with Mexican cactus and hoja santa, followed by a bite-sized Bocol tortilla filled with requesón cheese, topped with ribeye tartare and cactus salad. The Mexican cactus was prominently featured here, first as a key ingredient in the welcome drink and then again in the Bocol. Hoja santa, a common Mexican herb, brought bright notes to the traditional Japanese dashi, together with cactus, transforming the originally subtle broth into a more appetizing experience with its herbal aroma and slight acidity. However, the preparation of the second Bocol did not fully showcase Mexican characteristics. While the ingredients were Mexican, the overly French cooking technique gave it a feel more akin to an amuse bouche in a French restaurant, lacking the authentic Mexican flavor. Overall, this presentation was certainly impressive, but there remains room for improvement in the cultural fusion aspect.



The first dish presented is Em's most famous creation: Bluefin tuna crudo with Pasilla mixe chili kōshō and soy reduction. The dish clearly shows strong Japanese culinary influences at first glance. The bluefin tuna is expertly sliced with a standard sashimi knife skill and arranged on a large plate. While the price of the dish is not cheap, the portion size is quite generous.



Beneath the tuna lies a hidden surprise: avocado puree with fried fish scales. This addition perplexes me; the avocado puree clearly suggests guacamole, while the fish scales pay homage to the Japanese technique of Matsukasa-yaki. However, the essence of Matsukasa-yaki lies in the contrast between the crispy fish scales and the tender fish flesh. Combining crispy fish scales with raw fish seems unconvincing to me; in my view, it feels like a downgrade.

Traditionally, sashimi is paired with thin soy sauce, but here the chef replaces it with Pasilla mixe chili kōshō and soy reduction. By incorporating traditional Mexican chili in the form of yuzu pepper into a concentrated soy sauce, it may seem like a fusion of Mexican and Japanese cuisine. However, it ultimately feels disjointed. The resulting concoction is very thick, making it an unsuitable pairing for sashimi.



Before the main course arrived, an interesting bread course was presented, with butter laminated with totemoxtle ash.

By now, after a few days of exploring the local culinary scene, I was already familiar with totemoxtle. Corn husks and their ash are commonly used in Mexican cuisine. However, in this dish, its presence was rather understated. The rich, dense buttery aroma of the brioche overshadowed the subtle flavor of the totemoxtle ash, leaving it nearly imperceptible, what a missed opportunity.



Promptly came the short rib, braised and then covered with a dark mole negro sauce, accompanied by the dark bean puree, the bright-orange puree of pineapple and guajillo, and borage flower. The portion of beef was generous, almost too much for me to finish. The slow braising process had softened the meat perfectly. While the texture didn't reach the level of melt-in-your-mouth tenderness, it was still wonderfully tender and flavorful. The deep, earthy mole negro complemented the beef well, its slightly sweet and bitter richness enhancing the meat without overwhelming its natural meaty aroma and umami.

The accompanying ingredients took the dish in a contrasting direction. The bright, tropical notes of pineapple paired with the subtle heat of guajillo, whose sweet, fruity, tangy, and smoky profile — with hints of berries and tea — added complexity and depth to the beef, making it a memorable combination. However, despite the thoughtful pairing of flavors, I struggled to identify any clear Japanese influence in this dish.



Surprisingly, even with such a simple à la carte menu, the restaurant still offered a palate cleanser—though I wouldn't exactly call it a serious one. The waiter presented a roll wrapped in shiso leaf, filled with mint marshmallow, yuzu, and cucumber. While it was refreshing and undeniably an interesting combination, it didn't quite serve as a profound palate cleanser.

Next came the dish I had chosen: mamey tiramisu. Mamey is a popular local fruit, often described as having flavors that combine sweet potato, pumpkin, honey, prune, peach, apricot, cantaloupe, cherry, and almond. Its texture is creamy and soft, much like an overripe avocado. I chose tiramisu because it seemed to be the most intriguing dessert on the menu, but I wasn't particularly optimistic about it. First, tiramisu has been overused for a long time, with countless variations like matcha tiramisu and strawberry tiramisu.

Yet, in the end, we always seem to return to the original flavor. Second, making tiramisu is not a complicated process, and from what I saw here, the restaurant simply adhered to the most basic version: mixing mascarpone with cream made from mamey's seed—pixtle—replacing cocoa powder with mamey powder, and serving a slice of fresh mamey on the side to taste the fruit's true flavor.



After finishing, I would say that it was a decent dessert, but it still lacked novelty. Using a local fruit as the new flavor is a superficial approach when no effort is made to innovate the dessert's technique itself. It once again confirms what I've always said: the classic, original tiramisu will always be the best. Moreover, here I only see a fusion of Mexican and Italian cultures. So where are the Japanese elements that the restaurant has been touting?



Given the amuse bouche and palate cleanser, it seems only natural that a mignardise would follow the dessert even for such a simple menu. I had ordered the à la carte menu with three dishes, but in the end, it turned into an eight-course meal, which made it quite a good value. The final mignardise was a piece of nama chocolate with caramel and gold foil. The flavor was quite conventional, very much in line with typical Western-style desserts. There was neither any hint of Mexican chocolate nor any clear Japanese influence — despite the fact that it was a Japanese-style nama chocolate. Looking back at the meal, while it didn't offer a transformative experience, I was still overall satisfied with the flavors and sometimes pleasantly surprised by certain elements. In terms of innovative technique, Em seems to have reached a plateau — it's hard to imagine them achieving greater heights in this regard. The main issue I have is with their so-called fusion of Japanese elements. To me, this type of fusion feels unconvincing. The chef still has a long way to go, as his understanding of Japanese cuisine seems rather superficial.